



A climber for two where players bid contracts and 10s shovel sets
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Concept

Dopplin is a two-player climbing and shedding game played with a shortened double deck.

Players lead and beat singles, pairs, sets, runs, and connected sets. There are no bombs. Instead, 10s can shovel an opponent’s set into your hand, leaving the 10s behind as the new active play.

Before play begins, players bid for contracts that raise the stakes and set the terms of the hand: who leads, how set-aside cards enter play, and what the declarer must achieve. Victory comes from reading your hand, choosing the right contract, and knowing when to shed quickly, hold back, or shovel at the right moment.

Setup

Players: 2.
Cards: Use 2 standard 54-card decks and keep only 5s, 10s, J, Q, K, A, 2s, and Jokers, excluding all Diamonds. This gives exactly **46 cards**: 6 cards each of 10, J, Q, K, A, and 2; 4 ordinary 5s; 2 Heart 5s; 2 Small Jokers and 2 Big Jokers.
Deal: Deal **18 cards** to each player. Set the remaining **10 cards** aside face down, unused except as noted by certain contracts.
First bidder: Randomly choose the first bidder for the first hand. In later hands, the player with fewer points bids first. If scores are tied, the player who did not win the previous hand bids first.

Card Rank

Highest to lowest: Heart 5 > Big Joker > Small Joker > other 5s > 2 > A > K > Q > J > 10.
The **Heart 5** is separate from the other 5s. It cannot combine with other-suit 5s in pairs and sets. The two Heart 5s may still pair with each other.
Jokers may be played as singles or as same-kind pairs. They are not used in runs or connected sets.

Contracts

Before play, starting with the first bidder, players alternate chances to declare. A player may **pass** or declare a contract. Passing before any contract is declared does not end the auction. Once a contract has been declared, the other player may declare a stronger contract or pass. A pass after a contract has been declared ends the auction. A **Heavenly** declaration ends the auction immediately.
If both players pass, play **Quiet**; the first bidder leads first. If a contract is declared, the player who declared the final contract is the **declarer**.
In every declared contract the declarer’s aim is **to shed out before the non-declarer**. Unless a contract states otherwise, the declarer leads first and fails if the non-declarer sheds out first. The table lists only what each contract adds or changes.
Contract order: Quiet < Breakaway < Forced Shovel

< Clean Hands < Buried Treasure < Red Finish < The Chase < Blackout < Shutout < Heavenly.

Contract	Requirement
Quiet	No declarer. The first bidder leads first. The first player to shed out wins.
Breakaway Forced Shovel	No added conditions. Declarable only if the declarer holds at least one 10. To succeed, the declarer must either use shovel during the hand or include one or more 10s in their final play. Until then, they may not play 10s except as a shovel. Whenever a legal shovel is available, the declarer must perform it and may not pass or play a different combination instead.
Clean Hands	The declarer may not use shovel. Doing so is an immediate failure.
Buried Treasure	Before play, reveal the top 3 set-aside cards. The non-declarer takes 2 of them into their hand. The declarer takes the remaining 1.
Red Finish	The non-declarer leads first. The declarer’s final legal play must contain the Heart 5.
The Chase	Before play, the declarer takes the top 3 set-aside cards into their hand. The non-declarer leads first. The declarer must shed out before the non-declarer escapes. The non-declarer escapes the moment they have fewer than 3 cards after playing on their turn. Shoveling cannot trigger escape.
Blackout	The non-declarer leads first. The declarer may not lead a single to an empty pile. Doing so is an immediate failure.
Shutout	The declarer must shed out before the non-declarer plays any card. If the non-declarer plays any card first, the declarer fails immediately.
Heavenly	The declarer must complete a Shutout. Then, after the declarer’s final play, the non-declarer gets one last chance to beat it with a legal higher matching play. If they can, the declarer fails. Otherwise, the declarer succeeds.

Turn Flow

A lead may be any legal play. On your turn, either **pass** or play a legal combination that **beats the current play**. If the opponent passes, the last player who played clears the pile and leads again.
The hand ends when one player has no cards left, or earlier through contract failure or non-declarer escape.

Legal Plays

Play	Requirement
Single	1 card.
Pair	2 equal-rank cards. The two Heart 5s may pair. Same-kind Jokers may pair.
Set	3 to 6 equal-rank cards, where available: triple, quad, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind.
Single run	Exactly 4 or 5 consecutive singles, using only 10, J, Q, K, A.
Connected sets	3+ consecutive equal-size groups: connected pairs, triples, quads, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind groups. Only 10, J, Q, K, A may be used.

Comparison: A play only beats the **same type** with matching size, length, and structure. Connected sets must match both group size and number of groups. Sets compare by rank. Runs and connected sets compare by their highest card or highest group.

No bombs: There are no bombs and no cross-type beating.

Shovel

10s have a special **shovel** power. On your turn, you may play 10s to capture the opponent's current rank set if your 10-play has exactly one fewer card than the target set.

Shovel play	Captures
10	A pair.
10-10	A triple.
10-10-10	A 4-of-a-kind.
10-10-10-10	A 5-of-a-kind.
10-10-10-10-10	A 6-of-a-kind.

The captured set is added to the shoveling player's hand. The played 10s stay on the pile as the current active play. The opponent must now beat the 10s or pass.

Example: Opponent plays Q-Q-Q. You play 10-10. You take Q-Q-Q into your hand. The active play is now 10-10. A shovel may only capture the opponent's current play. You cannot shovel your own earlier play.

Limits: Shovel may capture only ordinary same-rank sets: 10s, Js, Qs, Ks, As, 2s, and ordinary 5s. It cannot capture Heart 5s or Jokers.

Scoring

Scoring format: Success / Failure. If the declarer succeeds, they score the first value; if they fail, the opponent scores the second value.

Contract	Score
Quiet	10
Breakaway	15 / 10
Forced Shovel	18 / 12
Clean Hands	24 / 16
Buried Treasure	27 / 18
Red Finish	42 / 28
The Chase	48 / 32
Blackout	54 / 36
Shutout	96 / 64
Heavenly	108 / 72

Card bonus: The player who scores the hand also scores 1 additional point for each card remaining in the opponent's hand, capped at the contract score they receive. No card bonus is awarded for Shutout or Heavenly.

In **Quiet**, there is no declarer: the first player to shed out scores 10 points.

Match: Play to **150 points** for a short match, or **250 points** for a longer match, or to any previously agreed number of hands or points. If playing to points, the match ends after a hand in which a player reaches the target.

Design Notes and Credits

Dopplin is mainly inspired by Dalian Red 5, with additional inspiration from Big A and Dou Dizhu.

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